

Introduction

Introduction to linguistics — **Course Website**

Dr. Quirin Würschinger, LMU Munich

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Outline

1. **Organisation**: How does this course work?
2. **Fundamentals**: What is language and how do linguists study it?
3. **Core concepts**: How do words get their meaning?
4. **Linguistic domains**: What are the core areas of linguistic analysis?
5. **Applied fields**: How is linguistics used in real-world applications?

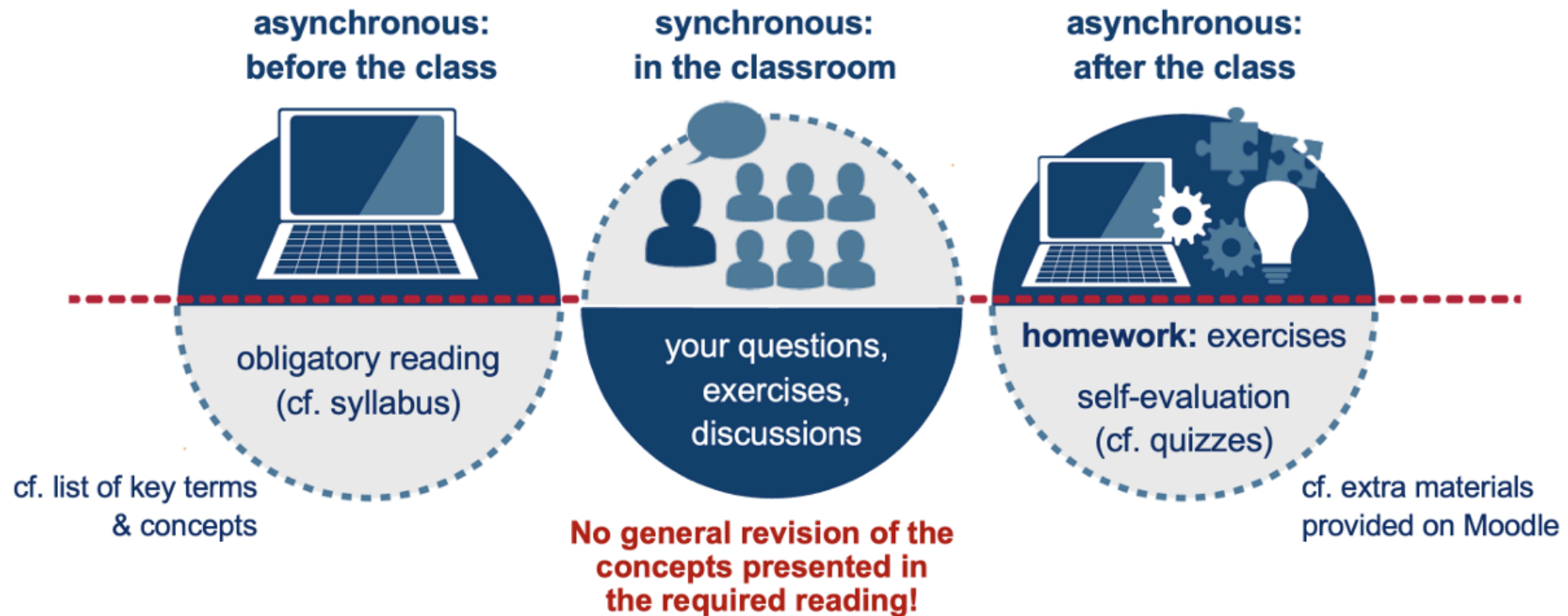
Organisation

Course materials

Course website: <https://wuqui.github.io/Intro252/>

Teaching approach: flipped classroom

- students prepare before class (readings, exercises);
- in-class time focuses on discussion and practice.



Related lectures

- **Lehramt Gymnasium:**
 - Take 'Grundlagenvorlesung' Linguistik (P 3.2) alongside 'Einführung in die Sprachwissenschaft' (P 3.1); strongly recommended.
- **Lehramt Real-/Mittel-/Grundschule** (Unterrichtsfach):
 - Take one 'Grundlagenvorlesung' (WP 3.2) alongside 'Einführung' (P 1.2); choose only one course labelled 'Grundlagenvorlesung' in WP 3.
- **BA Anglistik / BA TUM / BSc WiPäd II:**
 - Take the 'Grundlagenvorlesung' in the same semester as the intro; both are assessed in one module exam.

Lectures

- **Schmid:** *Topics in English linguistics*
- **Krischke:** *How languages work: A spotlight on English*

Registration

Any open issues?

Schedule

Date	Topic	Preparatory reading
20 Oct.	Organisation & introduction	Herbst (2010): ch. 2
27 Oct.	Pragmatics	Kortmann (2020): ch. 7
3 Nov.	Phonetics	Kortmann (2020): ch. 2.1
10 Nov.	Phonology	Kortmann (2020): ch. 2.2
17 Nov.	Syntax I	Herbst (2010): ch. 11.1–11.2
24 Nov.	Syntax II	Herbst (2010): ch. 11.3–11.4
1 Dec.	Morphology	Kortmann (2020): chs. 4.1, 3.1, 3.2; Herbst (2010): ch. 8;
8 Dec.	Word-formation	Kortmann (2020): ch. 3.3
15 Dec.	Semantics and lexicology	Kortmann (2020): ch. 6
22 Dec.	Revision	—
12 Jan.	Sociolinguistics	Kortmann (2020): ch. 8
19 Jan.	History of English	Bieswanger and Becker (2021): ch. 2
26 Jan.	Mock exam	—
2 Feb.	Exam	—

Requirements

- ☐ active participation
- ☐ readings
- ☐ exercises
- ☐ exam

Literature

Selected introductions to English linguistics:

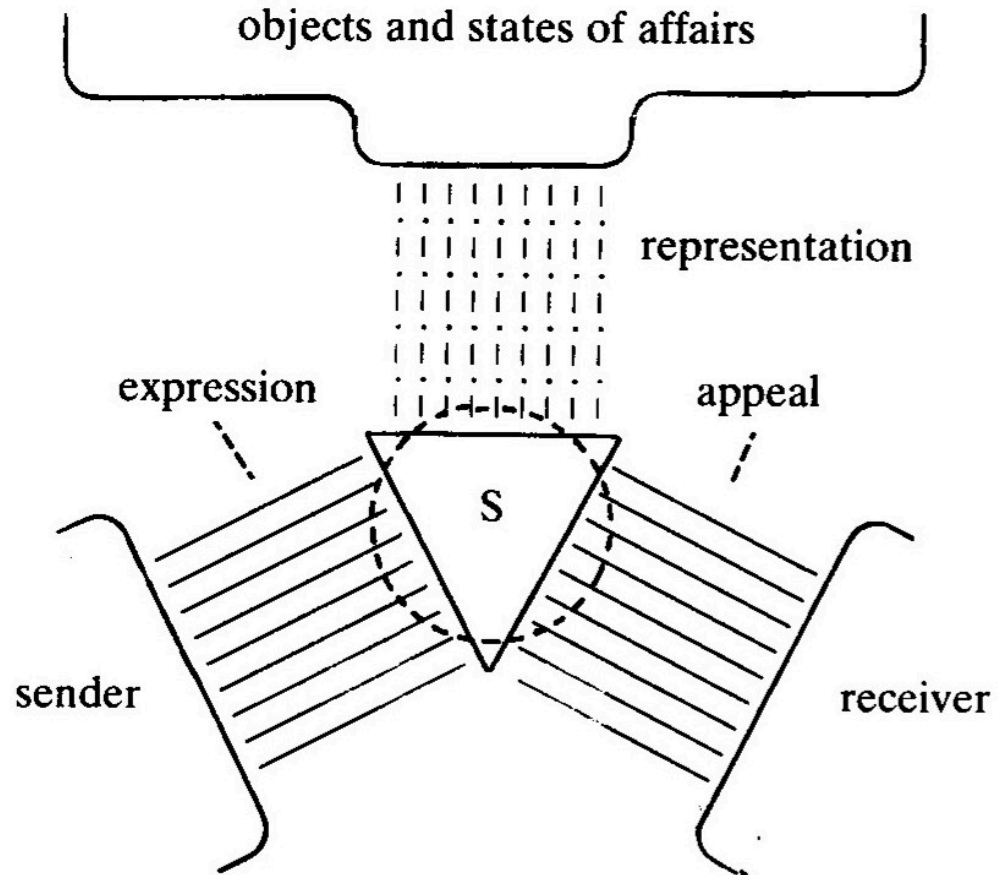
- Bieswanger, Markus & Annette Becker. 2021. Introduction to English linguistics. 5th ed. Tübingen: Narr.
- Herbst, Thomas. 2010. English linguistics: A coursebook for students of English. Berlin: De Gruyter.
- Kortmann, Bernd. 2020. English linguistics: Essentials. 2nd ed. Stuttgart: Metzler.
- Mair, Christian. 2022. English linguistics: An introduction. 4th ed. Tübingen: Narr.
- Plag, Ingo, Sabine Arndt-Lappe, Maria Braun & Mareile Schramm. 2015. Introduction to English linguistics. 3rd ed. Berlin: De Gruyter.
- Sauer, Hans & Kerstin Majewski. 2020. My first door to English linguistics: A short companion to the study of English. Tübingen: Stauffenburg.

All available as ebooks at the university library (<https://www.ub.uni-muenchen.de>).

Linguistic fundamentals

Language as a tool for communication

The Organon model ([Bühler 1934](#))



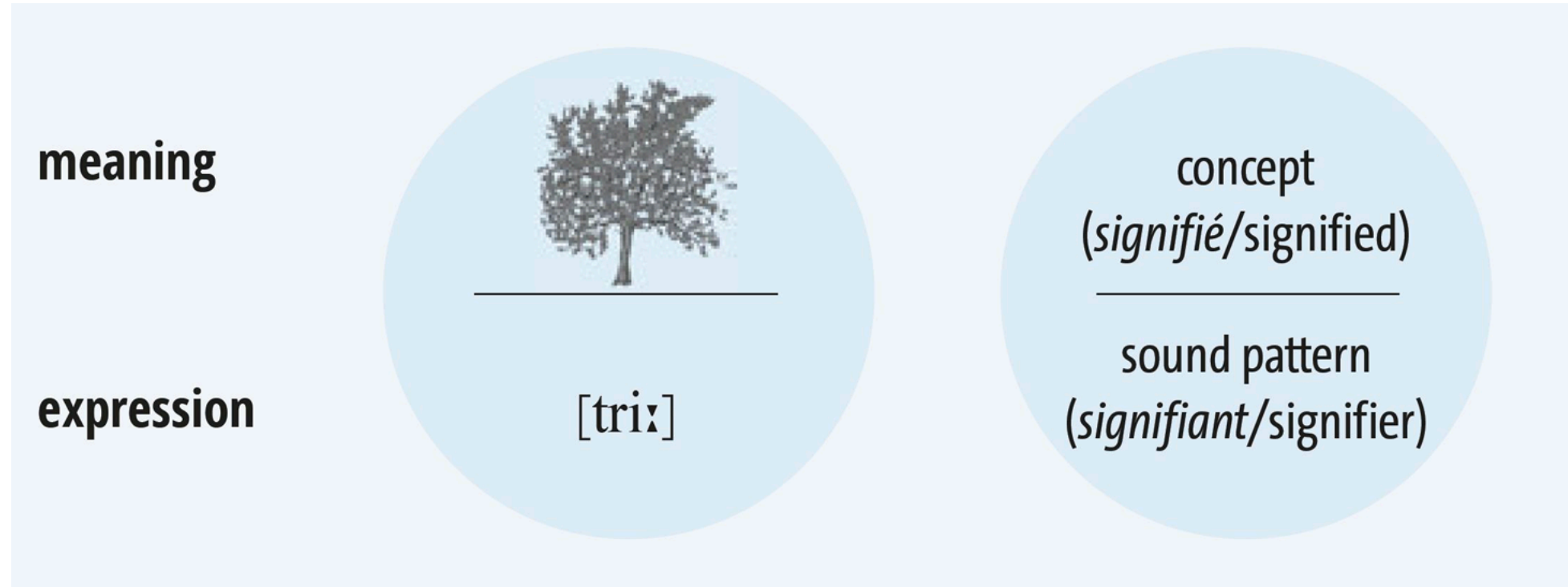
Structuralism

- The linguist who has, first and foremost, shaped linguistic thinking in the 20th century is **Ferdinand de Saussure (1857–1913)**.
- We know about his theory of language from a set of lecture notes from a lecture delivered at Geneva university, which were published by his students as *Cours de linguistique générale* in 1916.

(cf. Kortmann ([2020](#)), 5–9)



The model of the linguistic sign (**Saussure 1916**)



Bieswanger and Becker (2021): 6

De Saussure's concept of the linguistic sign

The linguistic sign has the following set of characteristics:

- **Reciprocity**

- The signifier/signifiant evokes the signified/signifié, and vice versa.

- **Arbitrariness**

- This relationship is unmotivated. There is no obvious reason why a particular signifier should represent a certain signified.

- **Conventionality**

- This relationship between signifier and signified is based upon an implicit 'agreement' between speakers of speech communities.

Different types of signs: Peirce

Three major types of signs depending on the relationship between signifier and signified:

- **symbol**
 - arbitrariness: lack of motivated link (cf. de Saussure's linguistic sign)
- **icon**
 - similarity: visual, acoustic, ... (e.g., meow for the cat)
- **index**
 - effect–cause or contiguity (i.e., proximity in space/time) (e.g., smoke as a sign of fire)

Exercise: symbols, icons, indices

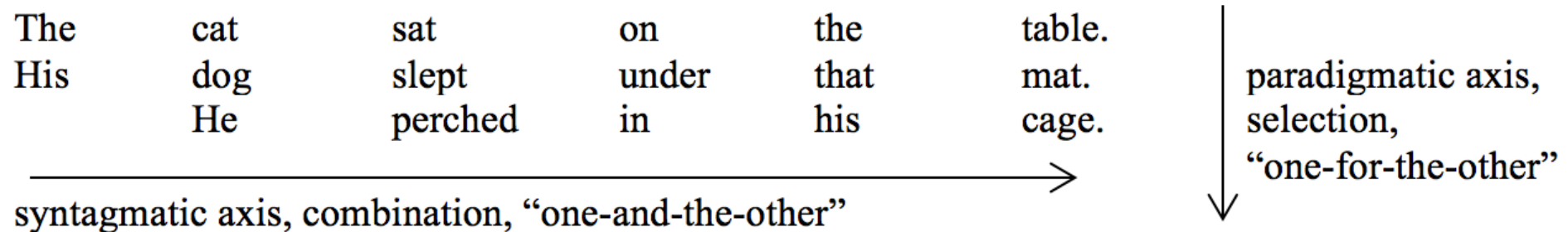
Classify each sign and state the underlying relationship (arbitrariness, similarity, contiguity).

Item	Sign	Relationship
1. traffic light colours	<u>symbol</u>	<u>arbitrariness (convention)</u>
2. portrait photo	<u>icon</u>	<u>similarity (visual)</u>
3. tree rings for a tree's age	<u>index</u>	<u>contiguity (systematic correlation)</u>
4. onomatopoeia of the word <i>click</i>	<u>icon</u>	<u>similarity (acoustic)</u>
5. national flag of Japan for the country	<u>symbol</u>	<u>arbitrariness (convention)</u>
6. wet footprints on the floor	<u>index</u>	<u>contiguity (proximity in space/time)</u>

Paradigmatic vs syntagmatic relations

Linguistic units (in phonology, word-formation, syntax etc.) stand in two types of relationships:

- Elements which co-occur in horizontal order form syntagms or “chain relationships”.
- Elements which replace each other in the same functional slot form paradigms or “choice relationships”.



Linearity of language

Language is linear: Saussure's signifier unfolds in time along the syntagmatic chain.

- In chat, the platform serialises turns with timestamps; order itself creates meaning.
- Simultaneous cues (emoji, read receipts, voice notes) are anchored to points on the chain; the app linearises them.
- Interpretation is path-dependent: earlier items license later ones (anaphora, ellipsis).
- Therefore, where spoken or written, language is always linear in the end.



Aim of structuralism and emancipation from de Saussure

Aim of Structuralism: Identifying and describing elements in the system (on all levels of a language: sounds, words and their components, sentences and their constituents) in terms of their paradigmatic and syntagmatic relationships to other elements in the system.

Since the 1960s ...

- renewed interest in language **variation** and **change** (vs primacy of synchrony)
- research into language use by individual speakers in different social situations
→ **pragmatics** & **sociolinguistics** (vs primacy of the system)
- recognition of **fuzzy boundaries/continua** and acceptance of dichotomies only as pedagogically useful idealisations (e.g., synchrony – diachrony, language system – language use, vocabulary – grammar, written language – spoken language)

Synchrony vs diachrony



Change of meaning over time ([Hamilton, Leskovec, and Jurafsky 2016](#))

- **Synchrony:**
 - study of the language system at a single time point; internal relations among elements.
- **Diachrony:**
 - study of change over time; how forms and meanings evolve.

Langue and parole

- **Langue:**
 - rules of the game
 - abstract linguistic system shared by a speech community; grammar and lexicon independent of individual use
- **Parole:**
 - how the game is actually played
 - concrete, individual language use in context; actual utterances with performance variation



Descriptivism vs prescriptivism

- **Descriptivism**

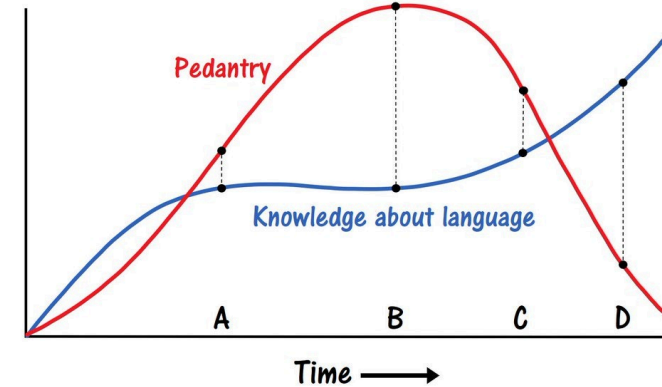
- describes how speakers actually use language without judging forms as right or wrong.
- e.g. accepting double negatives in some dialects as systematic grammar.

- **Prescriptivism**

- sets rules for how people ought to use language, often based on tradition or style.
- e.g. forbidding sentence-final prepositions in formal writing.

A graph and explanation of linguistic knowledge vs linguistic pedantry

@robdrummond



- A. Danger point. Increased knowledge about language has led to a surge in linguistic pedantry, resulting in an imbalance.
- B. Crisis point. Full on pedant. False confidence in good linguistic knowledge has led to pedantic half-truths outweighing facts.
- C. The road to recovery. Taking the time to understand how language actually works has led to a more tolerant outlook.
- D. A sensible place to be. The more you know about language, the more you see the nonsense of linguistic pedantry. Be aware that at point (D) you may be called upon to challenge people at point (B). This can be difficult, as people at point (B) often have the weight of public opinion behind them. Be patient, and encourage them to move towards point (C).

Object language vs metalanguage

Definitions

- **Object language**

- language used as the subject of description or analysis (the examples themselves).

- **Metalanguage**

- language used to talk about language (terms, rules, and descriptions).

Examples

1. Saying *shit* is not allowed.
2. *verb* is a noun.
3. I don't know the word for *word* in Spanish.

Exercise

1. The meaning of bank is ambiguous.
2. Noun phrases often start with the words the or a.
3. Morphology is the field of language which studies the formation of new words.
4. The past tense of verbs is formed by adding the suffix -ed.

1. The meaning of *bank* is ambiguous.
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Recap — Fundamentals

1. What are the key characteristics of the linguistic sign according to de Saussure?
2. What is the difference between syntagmatic and paradigmatic relations?
3. What is the difference between synchrony and diachrony?

Quiz

1. What does “arbitrary” mean in Saussure’s sign?
 - a. random noise;
 - b. no natural link between form and meaning;
 - c. unpredictable usage
2. Which substitution best illustrates a paradigmatic relation?
 - a. Replacing *student* with *teacher* in “The ___ reads the book”
 - b. Adding *quickly* after *reads*
 - c. Moving *the* to the end of the sentence
3. Which of the following is an index?
 - a. The word *tree*
 - b. A photograph of a cat
 - c. Smoke signalling fire

Linguistic domains

Overview

- language as **structure**: phonetics, phonology, morphology, semantics, syntax, text linguistics
- language as a **cultural and social phenomenon**: contact linguistics, historical linguistics, dialectology, pragmatics, sociolinguistics
- language as a **biological phenomenon**: neurolinguistics, psycholinguistics, cognitive linguistics
- practical **applications**: second language acquisition/teaching, compiling dictionaries, translation theory, computer linguistics, artificial intelligence research, forensic linguistics
- ...

Core domains

- phonetics and phonology
- morphology and word-formation
- syntax
- semantics
- pragmatics
- sociolinguistics
- historical linguistics
- ...

Phonetics and phonology

***Our Strange Lingo* (Lord Cromer)**

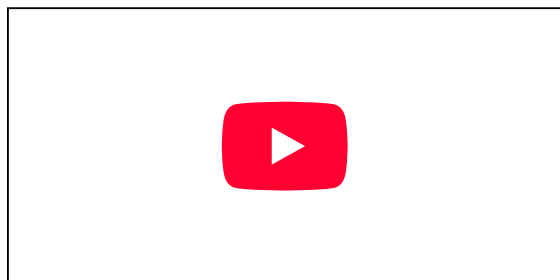
When the English tongue we speak.
Why is break not rhymed with freak?
Will you tell me why it's true
We say sew but likewise few?
And the maker of the verse,
Cannot rhyme his horse with worse?
Beard is not the same as heard
Cord is different from word.
Cow is cow but low is low
Shoe is never rhymed with foe.

Think of hose, dose, and lose
And think of goose and yet with choose
Think of comb, tomb and bomb,
Doll and roll or home and some.
Since pay is rhymed with say
Why not paid with said I pray?
Think of blood, food and good.
Mould is not pronounced like could.
Wherefore done, but gone and lone -
Is there any reason known?
To sum up all, it seems to me
Sound and letters don't agree.

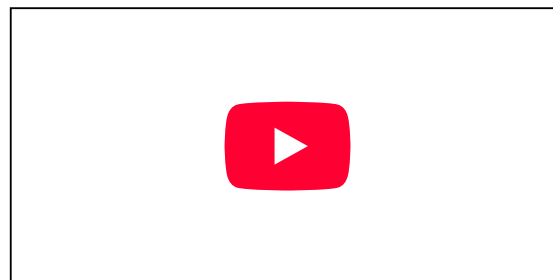
Phonetics and phonology

What do you hear?

Test



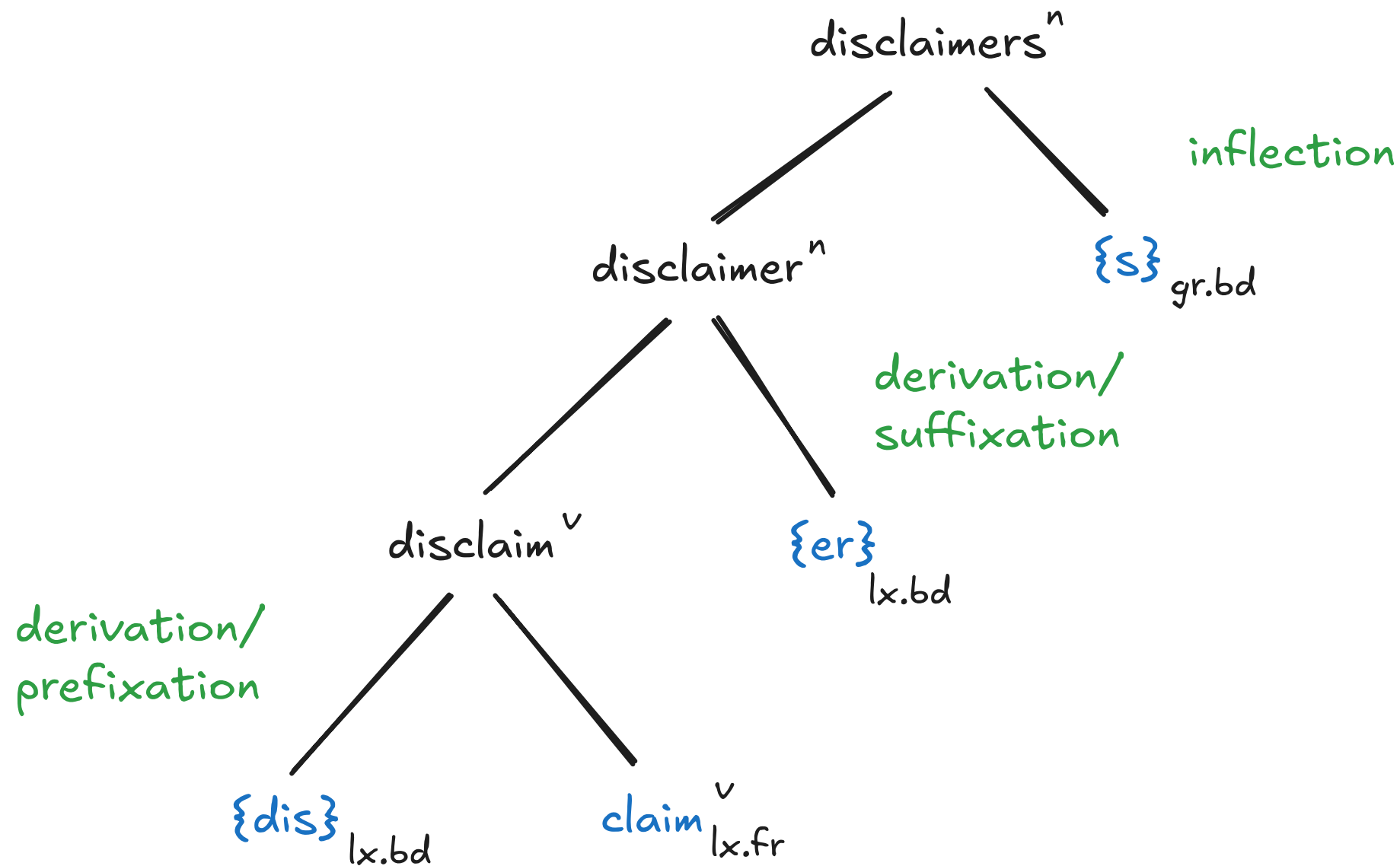
Analysis



Morphology and word-formation

Analysing complex words

1. How many parts does the word *disclaimers* consist of?
2. How can we analyse this complex word in terms of its parts?



Why and how do we form new words?

TWITTER



Donald J. Trump ✓
@realDonaldTrump

 Follow

Despite the constant negative press covfefe

RETWEETS
11,029

LIKES
13,430



12:06 AM - 31 May 2017

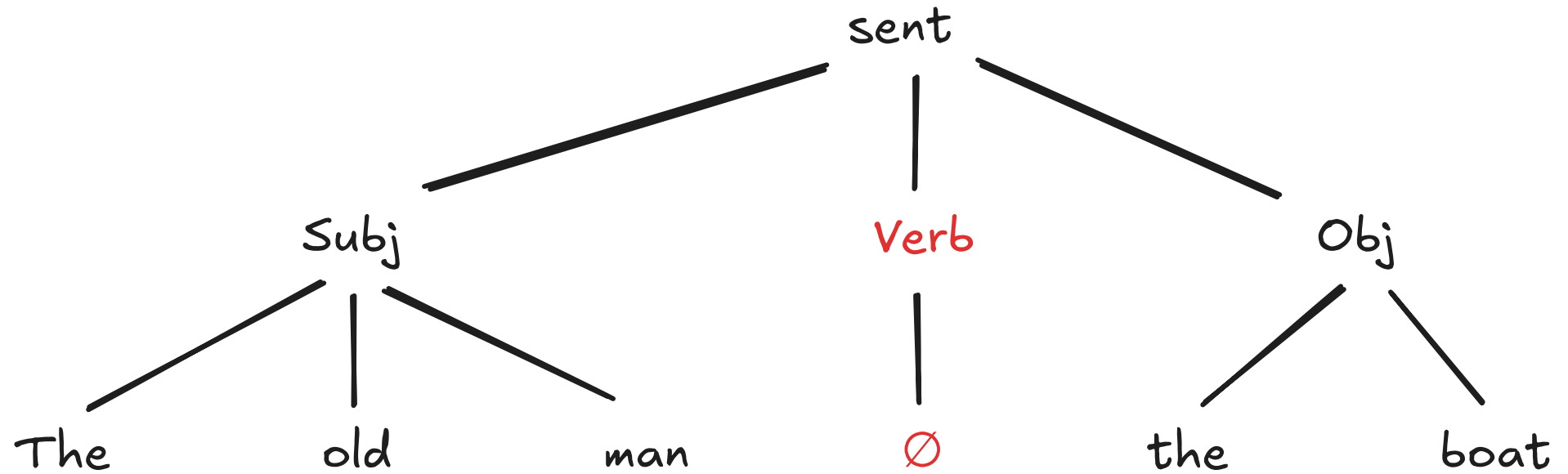
 7.8K  11K  13K 

Syntax

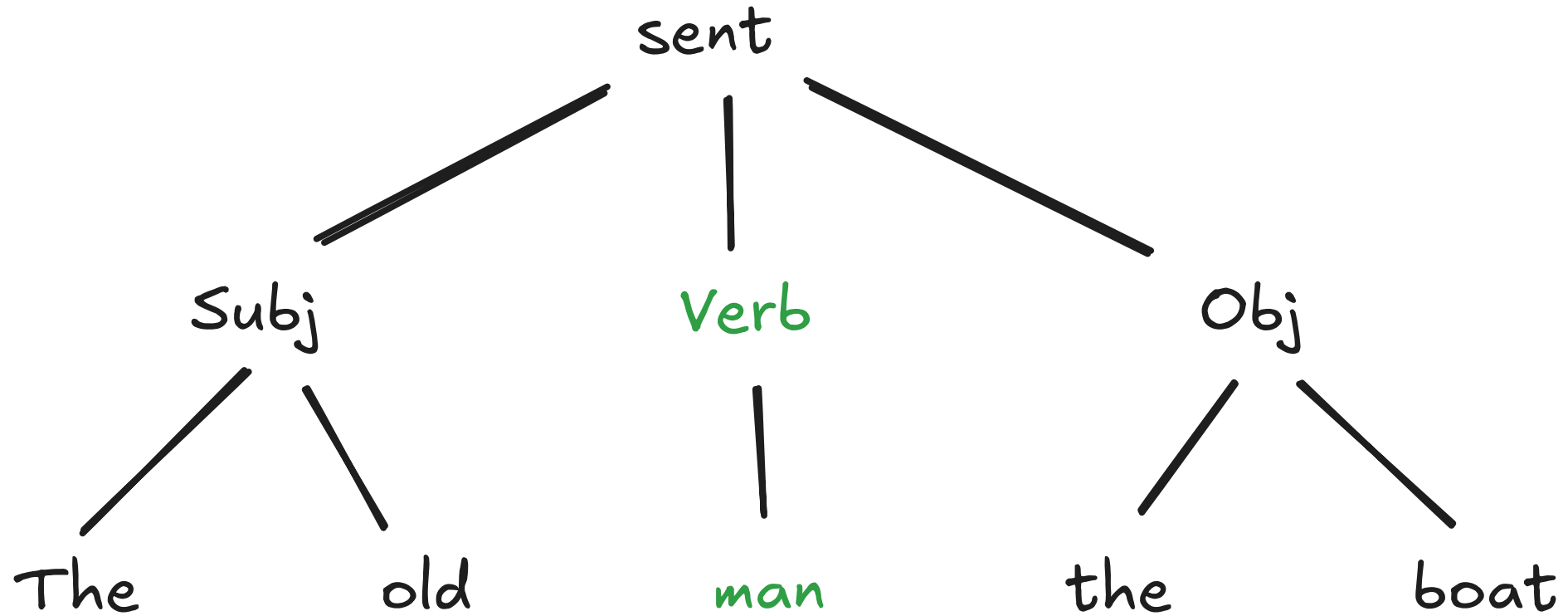
What's the problem with the following sentence?

The old man the boat.

The sentence is ungrammatical:



The sentence is grammatical:



Applied fields

Overview

- lexicography
- language acquisition and learning (teaching)
- cognitive linguistics and psycholinguistics
- computational linguistics
- forensic linguistics
- ...

Lexicography

linguistic, *adj.* and *n.*

Text size: A **A**

View as: [Outline](#) | [Full entry](#)

Quotations: [Show all](#) | [Hide all](#) Keywords: [On](#) | [Off](#)

Pronunciation: Brit.  /lɪŋˈɡwɪstɪk/, U.S.  /lɪŋˈɡwɪstɪk/

Frequency (in current use): ●●●●●●●●●●

Origin: Formed within English, by derivation. **Etymons:** [LINGUIST](#) *n.*, [-IC](#) *suffix*.

Etymology: < [LINGUIST](#) *n.* + [-IC](#) *suffix*.

Compare French *linguistique* (1826 or earlier), Spanish ... [\(Show More\)](#)

A. *adj.*

Of or relating to language; (also) of or relating to linguistics.

[Thesaurus »](#)
[Categories »](#)

1801 *German Museum* May 368 The linguistic monuments become more numerous in the thirteenth century, and the low-Saxon language appears in some of them.

1864 *Round Table* 18 June 4/3 She gives them phrases and words which..had their beginning long since that period, and are in fact linguistic anachronisms.

1876 C. M. DAVIES *Unorthodox London* (rev. ed.) 31 In a linguistic point of view the peoples were one.

1921 E. SAPIR *Lang.* vi. 156 In a book of this sort it is naturally impossible to give an adequate idea of linguistic structure.

1941 *Lowell* (Mass.) *Sun* 24 Jan. 4/4 It is not scientific to judge people and discriminate against them on basis of linguistic heritage, racial inferiority or religious differences.

1968 N. CHOMSKY & M. HALLE *Sound Pattern Eng.* i. 4 The essential properties of natural language are often referred to as 'linguistic universals'.

1992 *N.Y. Times Bk. Rev.* 16 Aug. 19/2 The child's level of linguistic competence.

2003 *Isis* 94 522/2 Delbrugge..notes some linguistic features of the text, mainly phonological, orthographic, and morphosyntactic ones.

The Oxford English Dictionary (OED)

Cognitive linguistics and psycholinguistics

The Stroop test foo

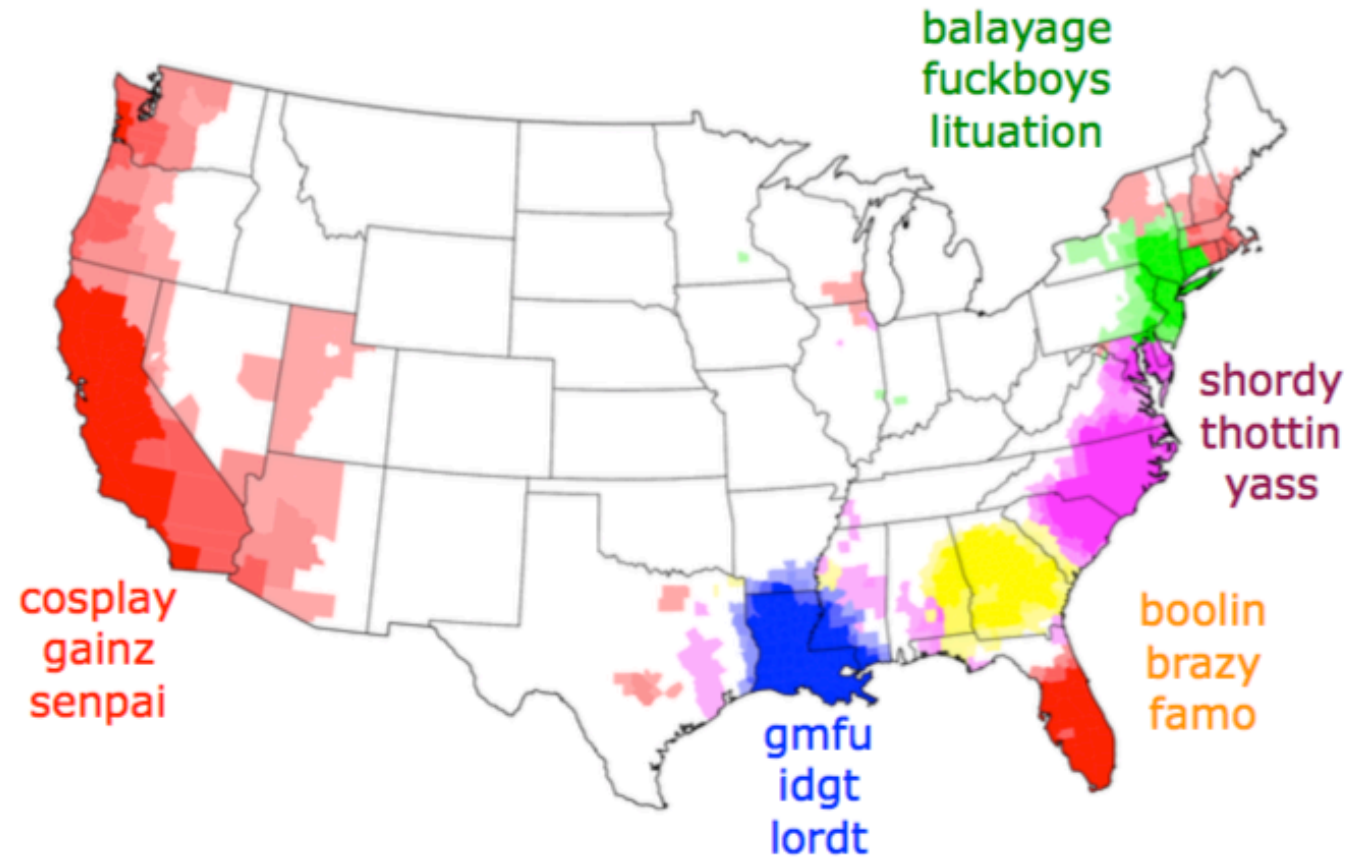
Green Red Blue
Purple Red Purple

Mouse Top Face
Monkey Top Monkey



Computational linguistics

Hubs of Lexical Innovation: Examples (Factor Loadings)



Hubs of lexical innovation (Grieve, Nini, and Guo 2018)

Summary and outlook

Key points

- Structuralism foregrounds synchrony and the linguistic system.
- Linguistic signs are reciprocal, arbitrary, and conventional.
- Relations: syntagmatic (chain) vs paradigmatic (choice).
- Peirce's triad: symbol (arbitrariness), icon (similarity), index (contiguity).
- Linguistics spans core domains and applied fields; methods and examples matter.

Next week: Pragmatics

Read Kortmann ([2020](#)): ch. 7

References

- Bieswanger, Markus, and Annette Becker. 2021. *Introduction to English Linguistics*. 5th ed. Tübingen: Narr Francke Attempto.
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- Grieve, Jack, Andrea Nini, and Diansheng Guo. 2018. "Mapping Lexical Innovation on American Social Media." *Journal of English Linguistics* 46 (4): 293–319.
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